

BARRIER BREAKERS · SPONSOR RECAP FOR 2027

Reach 8,000 students. Put the top 220 in one room.

Barrier Breakers is FinMango's one-day innovation challenge for Northeast Ohio high schoolers. In 2026, powered by Valmark, we promoted it to roughly **8,000 students** through our in-person classroom programming. About **220 of the top students** from those classrooms showed up on March 20 to pitch real solutions to the costs that hold families back.

~8,000

High school students reached in person through FinMango programming, where the event was promoted

~220

Top students from those classrooms who competed on event day

\$20K+

Cash awarded to student teams, funded by Valmark and our 2026 sponsors

How the pipeline worked

1

Teach in the classroom

FinMango delivers in-person financial education in Northeast Ohio high schools, reaching about 8,000 students over the year.

2

Invite the standouts

Students build a solution to a real barrier: transportation, housing, healthcare, or financial literacy. Teams of one to three register.

3

Compete on event day

Sixty-second pitches to a three-judge panel in the morning. Five finalists present to the whole room at Demo Day. Cash goes to the teams.

Barrier Breakers 2026 at a glance

Event date	March 20, 2026	Platinum sponsor	Valmark Financial Group · \$25,000
Students competing	~220	Demo Day finalists	5 teams
1st place prize	\$7,500 to the team	Minimum finalist prize	\$1,250



Students from across Northeast Ohio, checked in before the first pitch. March 20, 2026.

Valmark on the day

Valmark was the presenting sponsor of Barrier Breakers 2026 and was visible to every student in the building, from check-in through the awards.

- \$25,000 platinum sponsorship funded the prize pool
- Two Valmark judges on the Demo Day panel
- Valmark table and banner on the gallery floor all day
- Valmark judges presented awards alongside the panel



Valmark's table on the gallery floor, where students stopped between judging rounds.



The gallery round: sixty seconds to make the case, then questions from a judge.



Demo Day: five finalists present for five minutes each in front of every student in the room.



Awards: cash to the teams and a handshake from the judges, including Valmark's.